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PRUDENCE IN A MAZE OF METAPHORS



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Meet Prudence. A woman who lived in a world strikingly like ours. One morning, while getting herself ready to go to work and making breakfast for her twin daughters, she found herself adhered to her kitchen floor. No ordinary floor, this was an exceptionally **StickyFloor** that obstinately refused to let go. Despite her persistent scrubbing and mopping, the stickiness remained. She was going to be late for work. Again. Nevertheless, she persisted and fastened her boots, prepared to face the day.

Like every morning, her commute led her to the metro station, home to the notorious **LeakyPipeline** express. This peculiar train had a curious habit of misplacing female passengers at every station. Yet, Prudence, steadfast as ever, boarded the train, deftly avoiding the leaks while tightly clutching her dreams and ambitions.

Arriving at her office, she looked upwards, her eyes meeting with the expansive blue sky. Seeing the open sky while in the building always made her feel free even though she knew that, obscured from the naked eye, there was a **GlassCeiling**.

The elevator that morning was full. She'd been asked to head an emergency meeting, many floors up – an important opportunity, but she would have to take the treacherous **GlassCliff** stairs to get there. The stairway was infamous for its slippery steps and perilous edges. Armed with the endurance of a marathoner, she embarked on her daring climb up, each step echoing her unwavering resolve. As Prudence turned a corner on the treacherous **GlassCliff** stairs, she caught sight of Victoria, a VP she had long admired. Without looking up, Victoria, ever the firm's **Queen Bee**, muttered as Prudence passed by, "You have to earn your stripes." Prudence paused for a moment, then tightened her grip and continued her climb, feeling the weight of those words as cracks formed beneath her feet

As Prudence climbed the stairs, balancing the weight of deadlines and family obligations with resolve, another colleague appeared at her side. He was ascending leisurely. With a half-smile, he fell into step beside her and glanced at her heavy backpack filled with meeting notes, a forgotten lunch and a hastily scribbled grocery list. "You know," he **Mansplained**, his tone casual but authoritative, "The trick is not to take it all so seriously. Focus on what's important and leave the rest behind. Like, if I were you, I'd drop that heavy backpack. Take it easy, you'll climb faster."

His words, light as the briefcase he carried, hung in the air between them. She nodded politely, but with each step forward, the gap between his upward mobility and her reality grew wider, like the cracks in the glass she continued to step over.

During her climb, she encountered **DoubleBind** signs pointing in contrasting directions. One implored her to, "Be Assertive!" while the other entreated, "Be Nurturing!" Other signs said, "Take Charge," "Follow Instructions," "Speak Your Mind," "Keep the Peace," "Dream Big," "Stay Grounded." With a knowing though weary smile, Prudence understood she must embrace both messages and build a spectrum of diverse skills.

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Upon reaching her designated floor, she steeled her resolve and headed into the first of the day's tasks. With the prowess of a seasoned acrobat, she juggled meetings, presentations, reports, several reminders from her children's school and a growing list of groceries she must remember to buy on her way home.

As her working day concluded, the sting of the **MotherhoodPenalty** pricked at her. She felt her colleagues questioned if she really needed to depart early for her children and made it clear they resented that any work not yet finalized might fall on them. Her boss doubted that she would be able to shoulder any additional responsibilities. A familiar and growing sense of unease whispered that her dedication to her family might inadvertently cast a shadow over her career. Though exhausted by her work and more by the **MotherhoodPenalty** she faced, Prudence hesitated... maybe she should stay just a bit longer?

Prudence made her way through the bustling city streets, her mind pre-occupied with the day's work. As she neared the **Intersection**, a place she crossed every evening, it seemed more crowded than usual. On one corner, an older woman with deep lines etched into her weathered brown face, moved slowly, almost in defiance of the impatient ticking of the pedestrian light, as she made her way to the other side before the signal changed. Nearby, a woman in a wheelchair paused at the curb, her path blocked by the absence of a ramp, her frustration palpable in the fading light. Another woman, with curly hair tied in a scarf, pushed her three kids while she carried two bags full of groceries. The city streets were alive with so many life stories, with a mosaic of women hurrying by, each absorbed in her own world.

Once at home, Prudence set to work through the tasks of her **SecondShift** on **TheInvisibleJob**. Several hours later, tired and up later than she'd intended – again – she went to bed wondering if she was ready to do it all over again the next day? As doubts crept in, she began to question her abilities, her achievements and her strength; the specter of **ImposterSyndrome** loomed large, casting its shadow over her pillow. In the quiet of the night, she lay awake, pondering: Who was the real imposter? Was it her – or the convoluted **Maze** of obstacles surrounding her?

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Exhibit 1: Breaking the code: metaphors of gender and career

	Metaphor	Definition
	Sticky Floor	Represents societal or self-imposed limitations that prevent individuals, particularly women, from advancing in their careers despite their capabilities.
	Leaky Pipeline	Refers to the gradual loss of women and underrepresented groups as they progress in their careers, often due to systemic barriers or life-stage conflicts.
	Glass Ceiling	Symbolizes the invisible barriers that prevent women and minorities from reaching top leadership positions despite their qualifications and efforts.
	Glass Cliff	Refers to the precarious leadership positions often offered to women and minorities during times of crisis, increasing their risk of failure.
	Queen Bee	Women leaders who assimilate into male-dominated organizations by distancing themselves from junior women, thus legitimizing gender inequality in their organization.
	Mansplaining	Depicts the condescending explanations often given by men to women, because they assume women know less or require guidance on matters they are already knowledgeable in.
	Double Bind	Illustrates the conflicting expectations placed on women – such as the need to be both assertive and nurturing, ambitious yet humble – that often results in career-family tensions.
	Motherhood Penalty	Refers to the career setbacks women face due to assumptions about their availability and commitment after becoming mothers.
	Second Shift	Describes the additional unpaid labor women often undertake at home, such as childcare and household responsibilities, after their formal workday ends.
	Invisible Job	Refers to the unseen emotional and mental labor women manage in the household that are often unnoticed in the workplace.
	Imposter Syndrome	Represents internalized self-doubt experienced by individuals, often women and underrepresented groups, who feel undeserving of their success or question their abilities.
	Intersectionality	Refers to the overlapping and interdependent systems of discrimination or disadvantage that individuals may face due to their multiple social identities (e.g. race, gender, class, sexuality, disability).
	Maze	Refers to the multiple challenges women experience in their careers and the number of barriers they face throughout their journey.

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